

OVERVIEW

Mathematically rich tasks often intentionally lack specificity about how students should approach them. That ambiguity can actually help to build problem-solving skills and to facilitate mathematical transfer; but it can also leave students overwhelmed and unsure of how to move forward (or even get started). In this conversation, you'll have an opportunity to explore when and how different instructional choices might help students to get "unstuck."

SPARK MEDIA & FOCUS LESSON

Animated Video

A teacher considers a variety of ways to respond to students who are unsure how to get started, in the lesson [Hair Today, Gone Tomorrow](#).

PEDAGOGICAL THEME

Deepening Mathematical Understanding

USING THE CONVO GUIDE FOR A GREAT ROUNDTABLE DISCUSSION

- This conversation is designed for a group of 2-5 educators over 30-60 minutes.
- The Convo Guide serves as an agenda for a roundtable conversation where everyone is there both to learn and to share their expertise.
- Each participant should have their own copy of the Convo Guide and access to the Spark Media.
- Pace yourselves to get through the entire agenda in the time you have.
- Questions aren't intended to have a single right answer; instead, they're designed to spark rich discussions.
- At the end, everyone will commit to trying "one small thing" the very next day. Consider how you might follow up with one another!

OBSERVE

5-15 MIN

- To start, take a look at the Spark Media.
- What are some of the reasons students struggle to get started?
- Which approaches in the video address each underlying reason?

DISCUSS

10-15 MIN

- What questions/strategies could help a teacher discern which approach is best in a given moment?
- When might getting stuck serve as a productive part of learning? How do you discern the difference between productive and unproductive struggle?
- How could the teacher support students in building habits of mind and tools for navigating complex problems?

RELATE

10-15 MIN

- What norms, routines, or expectations do you have for how students ask questions in your classroom, and how do they help students get started without getting stuck?
- Are there any new moves you'd like to try to help students when they're stuck...or to avoid them getting stuck in the first place?
- To prepare to respond to stuck students while *teaching*, what could you think about or do during your *lesson planning*?

...AND COMMIT!

5-10 MIN

- What is one small thing you can do tomorrow in support of those shifts?